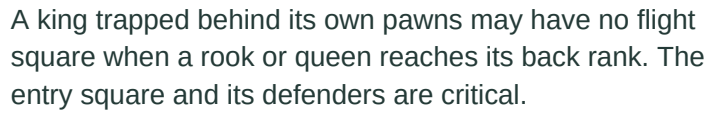


Back-rank mates

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES



Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on b8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and queen on a3. Check for tactical protection.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

24.Rg8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From g8 it attacks king on b8 and rook on h8. Recorded reply: **24...Rxb8**.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on b8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on g8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.